

TOOLS OF THE TRADE

All educated people knew how to cut a pen from a goose feather using a penknife. Playwrights and scribes, who did a lot of writing, had to keep their penknife close at hand, ready for when the quill's tip wore out and a new one needed to be cut. Rich people used fancy knives with decorative carving, but playwrights like Shakespeare would probably have used plain, simple knives.

The word pen comes from the Latin word penna, meaning feather

LAST WORDS

Robert Greene (c. 1558–1592) was dying when he wrote his attack on Shakespeare. The document was found among his papers after his death and was published immediately. This picture of Greene writing in his funeral shroud symbolizes the fact that his words of attack came from beyond the grave.



William Shakespeare's signature

RAPID WRITING

Writing seemed to come easily to William Shakespeare. His fellow playwright Ben Jonson wrote that "Whatsoever he penned, he never blotted out a line." Jonson, a slow and careful writer, considered Shakespeare's ease and speed to be a sign of carelessness.

A Persian painting showing Timur on his throne

Carved penknives

Dr. Faustus summons a devil using magic



POETIC PLAYS

The writer who most influenced Shakespeare's poetry was Christopher Marlowe (1564–1593). Marlowe put stirring speeches into the mouths of tragic heroes such as Dr. Faustus, a scholar who sells his soul to the devil. Marlowe's influence can be seen in the opening line of Shakespeare's early play *Henry VI Part One*, "Hung be the heavens with black, yield day to night!"

ASTOUNDING TERMS

Marlowe's first play *Tamburlaine* tells the story of Timur, a 14th-century Turkish warrior. Marlowe portrays Tamburlaine (Timur), "Threatening the world with high astounding terms, and scourging kingdoms with his conquering sword."

